

an accountant's laptop that contains vital company information, or your browser's cache which contains your various passwords, it's all up for grabs! Since there are so many ways that people try and get into PCs, we'll break them up into the following categories to give you a general idea what to look out for.

Adware / Spyware

There's a fine line between adware and spyware: very often, they go hand in hand, but a lot of software products are adware-supported and do not contain spyware. The perfect example here is the Opera browser—it just displayed ads from Google, and contained no spyware. However, many software (especially desktop theme packs, screensavers and the like), are filled with spyware. Very often, a smaller software company will bundle their software with adware or spyware from a bigger company, because the former has to cover development costs. In fact, sadly, a lot of the "freeware" out there is adware- or spyware-supported.

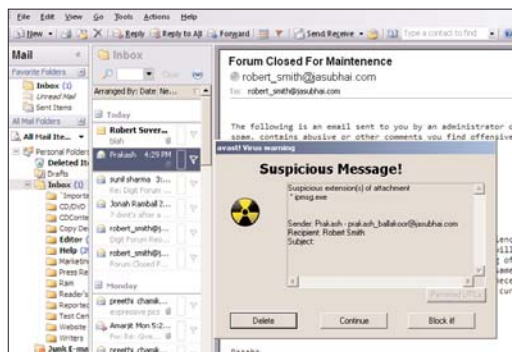
What you need to do is make sure all your computers are protected with anti-spyware tools. Two excellent examples here are Spybot Search & Destroy, and AdAware. Make it a policy for your employees to check and clean their PCs frequently using these tools. It's accomplished at the press of a button.

You could also make sure that none of your employees are allowed to install anything without permission from the system administrator. The simplest way to do this in Windows XP is to have your admin password-protect the Administrator accounts on all PCs, and make lower-level accounts for employees.

ActiveX

Though a lot of good software uses this Internet Explorer-based browser installer to integrate its content or services with Windows, many more sites try and trick users into installing malicious ActiveX code into their browsers. If ever there was a software that did more harm than good, it has to be ActiveX!

Be aware of the fact that many of your employees probably visit "warez" sites. If you're in a position to do so, enforce a policy that dictates that no employee should visit such sites—your admin's logs should tell you who was where on the Net. We say this because virtually any software "crack" downloaded from warez sites contains



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